The Practice of the Presence of God

BROTHER LAWRENCE

The Practice
of the Presence of God

ANNOTATED EDITION

The conversations and letters
with a plain-language note on every chapter
and a 30-day practice

INTRODUCTION AND NOTES BY ANDREAS RUPP

The Practice of the Presence of God (Annotated)
The Classic Conversations and Letters of Brother Lawrence – with a Plain-Language Note on Every Chapter and a 30-Day Practice

The conversations and letters of Brother Lawrence (Nicolas Herman, c. 1614–1691) were first published in French in 1692 and 1694. This edition follows the anonymous English translation published by the Fleming H. Revell Company, New York, which is in the public domain. The translator's wording and notes are kept; obvious printing errors are corrected.

Introduction, biography, a note on every conversation and letter, practices, the 30-Day Practice, the Quick Finder, the glossary, the afterword, cover and interior design © 2026 Andreas Rupp. All rights reserved.

Please note: This book is about a spiritual practice. It is not medical, psychological, financial or legal advice. The practices in this book can go alongside professional help, never instead of it. If you are ill or in crisis, please see a doctor or a qualified professional. In an emergency, call 911 (US) or 999 (UK).

Edited by Andreas Rupp

A little lifting up of the heart suffices.

BROTHER LAWRENCE, THIRD LETTER

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How to Use This Book

This is a small book, and it is tempting to read it in one evening. You can. But it was never meant to be finished so much as lived with. Brother Lawrence did not write a system. He talked with a visitor and answered letters from friends, and almost every page circles back to one simple idea: God is here, now, in the middle of whatever you are doing, and you can turn toward him at any moment.

The best way to take that in is slowly. Try reading one conversation or one letter a day. Most take only five or ten minutes. Read it once silently, then read a paragraph or two aloud. Old English sounds strange at first, but spoken aloud its rhythm softens, and you will notice phrases you skimmed past the first time. When a line catches you, stop there. You do not have to get to the end.

Here is how this edition is built.

The complete text. You have the whole of the Revell translation: the publisher's preface, the four conversations and the fifteen letters, with the translator's four footnotes. Nothing has been cut or modernized.

After each conversation and letter you will find three short pieces. A *Reflection* says in plain words what the section is about and what it might mean for a reader today. A *Practice* suggests one small, concrete thing to try in an ordinary day: at the sink, at your desk, in traffic, at the dinner table. A *Key Line* gives you a few words from the section to carry with you. Below it there is room for your own notes. Use it. Write down what you tried, what happened, what you resisted.

The 30-Day Practice gathers the heart of the book into a month of daily steps, one quotation and one small task for each day. You can use it

after a first reading, or instead of reading straight through.

The Quick Finder points you to the right pages when you come to the book with a particular need: a bad day at work, a restless mind, a long illness, a sense of failure.

The Glossary explains old words and church terms, so you are never stuck on vocabulary.

There is no wrong way to begin. Open anywhere, read a little, and then go back to your day. That, in the end, is what Brother Lawrence would want.

Who Was Brother Lawrence?

He was born Nicolas Herman around 1614 in Hériménil, a village in the duchy of Lorraine, in what is now northeastern France. He had little schooling; the preface calls him "a lowly and unlearned man." As a young man he became a soldier in the Thirty Years' War, the long and brutal conflict that ravaged much of Europe, and he was wounded. Years later, in the Second Conversation, he mentions that he was lame.

The most famous moment of his story happened when he was about eighteen. In winter he looked at a tree stripped bare of its leaves. He knew that in a little while the leaves would come back, and after them the flowers and the fruit. That plain sight gave him, as he later put it, a high view of the providence and power of God, and it never left him. Many people have had a moment like that. What is unusual is that he let it shape the next sixty years.

After the army he worked as a footman, a household servant, for a man named Fieubert, a treasurer. By his own cheerful account he was a great awkward fellow who broke everything. In 1640 he entered the priory of the Discalced Carmelites on the rue de Vaugirard in Paris. "Discalced" means barefoot, or sandaled, a sign of the order's simplicity. He came not as a priest but as a lay brother, one of the members who did the manual work of the house, and he took the religious name Lawrence of the Resurrection.

He was assigned to the kitchen. He tells us he naturally disliked the work, yet he stayed at it for many years, and it was there, among pots and crowded orders and noise, that he learned what he would later call the practice of the presence of God. In later life he was moved to the sandal

repair shop. He was also sent on errands he found hard, such as buying the community's wine in Burgundy, where he had to roll himself over the casks on the boat because of his bad leg.

The text shows us a man who was humble, plain-spoken and remarkably free of worry. He did not like fuss or elaborate methods. He was honest about his own long struggles, including years of fear that he was lost, and equally honest about the peace that came after. People noticed his face: calm, kind, never hurried and never idle.

Word of him spread beyond the priory walls. Among his visitors was Joseph de Beaufort, a priest who later served as vicar general to Cardinal de Noailles, Archbishop of Paris. Beaufort met him for the first time on August 3, 1666, and wrote down what Lawrence told him. Those notes are the four Conversations in this book.

Brother Lawrence died on February 12, 1691, in his late seventies. Soon afterward Beaufort gathered his letters and other material and published them in French, in 1692 and 1694.

The little book traveled far beyond the Catholic world in which it was born. It was translated into English more than once in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries and printed again and again. Protestant publishers and readers took it up as warmly as Catholic ones, and this very translation came from an American evangelical publishing house. It has been valued across Christian traditions ever since, perhaps because it asks for nothing complicated. It does not ask you to agree with anyone about doctrine or church order. It asks only that you remember God, often and simply, wherever you are.

The Practice in Brief

To practice the presence of God sounds like a technique. For Brother Lawrence it was closer to a friendship. He believed God is always present, closer than our own thoughts, and that the only thing missing is our attention. The practice is simply to keep turning that attention toward him, again and again, through the whole day, until it becomes as natural as breathing.

Here are its main features as the text describes them.

Short inward prayers. Lawrence did not recommend long speeches to God. He suggested quick, silent turnings of the heart, a word or a glance, which he calls "little internal adorations." A single sentence is enough, such as the one he used himself: "My God, here I am all devoted to Thee." Nobody around you needs to notice. He wrote to a friend that even a soldier on the march with a sword in hand could pray this way.

Coming back when the mind wanders. Everyone's attention drifts. Lawrence admits that in his early years he spent whole prayer times pushing distractions away and falling back into them. His advice is not to fight or scold yourself. When you notice you have wandered, come back gently and calmly. The return itself is the prayer. Over time the habit grows, and returning becomes easier.

Small things done for love. Lawrence's great discovery was that holiness does not depend on changing what you do, but on why you do it. Flipping an omelet, picking up a straw from the floor, answering an email, folding laundry: any of these can be offered to God. He believed God looks less at the size of the task than at the love behind it.

No special place or time. Lawrence kept the regular prayer times of his community, but he found no real difference between them and the rest of his day. The busy kitchen was as holy to him as the chapel. You do not need a retreat, a quiet house or an hour of free time. You need only to remember.

Peace instead of anxiety about faults. He was very aware of his failings, but he refused to be crushed by them. When he slipped, he told God plainly, asked for help, and then went back to his practice without dwelling on it. He saw endless self-reproach as another distraction from God, not a deeper form of holiness.

Love rather than fear. Lawrence had suffered for years from the fear that he was damned. What finally freed him was not a clever argument but the decision to love God whatever happened. From then on, love was his motive and his method. He did not practice God's presence to earn a reward or to avoid punishment, but because he found God good and wanted to be with him.

None of this requires special talent. In his own words, it needs "neither art nor science," only a willing heart and a little perseverance. You begin where you are, today, with whatever is in front of you.

A Note on This Text

Brother Lawrence's conversations and letters first appeared in French, in two small collections published in 1692 and 1694, shortly after his death. They were soon read outside France, and several English translations followed.

The translation printed here is anonymous. This edition follows the version issued by the Fleming H. Revell Company of New York, Chicago and Toronto, which described itself as "Publishers of Evangelical Literature," in the late nineteenth century. We reproduce its text in full and do not modernize it.

The short publisher's preface is kept as it was printed. It is a period piece and has its own warmth. Readers should know that it contains one error: it says Lawrence was admitted to the Carmelites in 1666. In fact he entered in 1640; 1666 is the year Beaufort first met him, as the First Conversation states.

The translator added four footnotes. They are kept here, marked [1] to [4], and printed at the end of the section where they occur. The second footnote tells us that the closing pages of the Fourth Conversation were gathered from other accounts of Brother Lawrence rather than from Beaufort's own talks with him.

The translator printed GOD, LORD and FATHER in capitals, a mark of reverence common in devotional books of the time. We have kept these in the text, while our own notes use ordinary spelling.

Some words are old-fashioned or have shifted in meaning: "physic" for medicine, "religion" for life in a religious order, "divers" for various,

"vouchsafe" for grant. The Glossary at the back explains these and other terms.

The Practice of the Presence of God

FOUR CONVERSATIONS · FIFTEEN LETTERS

Preface

THIS BOOK consists of notes of several conversations had with, and letters written by Nicholas Herman, of Lorraine, a lowly and unlearned man, who, after having been a footman and soldier, was admitted a Lay Brother among the barefooted Carmelites at Paris in 1666, and was afterwards known as "Brother Lawrence."

His conversion, which took place when he was about eighteen years old, was the result, under God, of the mere sight in midwinter, of a dry and leafless tree, and of the reflections it stirred respecting the change the coming spring would bring. From that time he grew eminently in the knowledge and love of GOD, endeavoring constantly to walk "*as in His presence*." No wilderness wanderings seem to have intervened between the Red Sea and the Jordan of his experience. A wholly consecrated man, he lived his Christian life through as a pilgrim—as a steward and not as an owner, and died at the age of eighty, leaving a name which has been as "ointment poured forth."

The "Conversations" are supposed to have been written by M. Beaufort, Grand Vicar to M. de Chalons, formerly Cardinal de Noailles, by whose recommendation the letters were first published.

The book has, within a short time, gone through repeated English and American editions, and has been a means of blessing to many souls. It contains very much of that wisdom which only lips the Lord has touched can express, and which only hearts He has made teachable can receive.

May this edition also be blessed by GOD, and redound to the praise of the glory of His grace.

First Conversation

THE FIRST time I saw *Brother Lawrence*, was upon the 3d of August, 1666. He told me that GOD had done him a singular favor, in his conversion at the age of eighteen.

That in the winter, seeing a tree stripped of its leaves, and considering that within a little time the leaves would be renewed and after that the flowers and fruit appear, he received a high view of the Providence and Power of GOD, which has never since been effaced from his soul. That this view had perfectly set him loose from the world, and kindled in him such a love for GOD, that he could not tell whether it had increased during the more than forty years he had lived since.

That he had been footman to M. Fieubert, the treasurer, and that he was a great awkward fellow who broke everything.

That he had desired to be received into a monastery, thinking that he would there be made to smart for his awkwardness and the faults he should commit, and so he should sacrifice to GOD his life, with its pleasures: but that God had disappointed him, he having met with nothing but satisfaction in that state.

That we should establish ourselves in a sense of GOD'S Presence, by continually conversing with Him. That it was a shameful thing to quit His conversation, to think of trifles and fooleries.

That we should feed and nourish our souls with high notions of GOD; which would yield us great joy in being devoted to Him.

That we ought to *quicken*, i.e., *to enliven, our faith*. That it was lamentable we had so little; and that instead of taking *faith* for the rule of their conduct, men amused themselves with trivial devotions, which changed daily. That the way of Faith was the spirit of the Church, and that it was sufficient to bring us to a high degree of perfection.

That we ought to give ourselves up to GOD, with regard both to things temporal and spiritual, and seek our satisfaction only in the fulfilling of His will, whether he lead us by suffering or by consolation, for all would lie equal to a soul truly resigned. That there needed fidelity in those dryness, or insensibilities and irksomenesses in prayer, by which GOD tries our love to him; that *then* was the time for us to make good and effectual acts of resignation, whereof one alone would oftentimes very much promote our spiritual advancement.

That as for the miseries and sins he heard of daily in the world, he was so far from wondering at them, that, on the contrary, he was surprised that there were not more, considering the malice sinners were capable of; that for his part he prayed for them; but knowing that GOD could remedy the mischiefs they did when He pleased, he gave himself no farther trouble.

That to arrive at such resignation as GOD requires, we should watch attentively over all the passions which mingle as well in spiritual things as in those of a grosser nature; that GOD would give light concerning those passions to those who truly desire to serve Him. That if this was my design, viz., sincerely to serve GOD, I might come to him (B. Lawrence) as often as I pleased, without any Fear of being troublesome; but if not, that I ought no more to visit him.



REFLECTION

Joseph de Beaufort meets Brother Lawrence in August 1666 and writes down what he hears. The story starts with a bare tree in winter. Looking at it, the

young Nicolas understood that leaves, flowers and fruit would come back, and that a faithful God was quietly at work behind it all. That one look stayed with him for over forty years. He laughs at himself as a clumsy footman "who broke everything," and he admits he went into the monastery expecting to be punished, only to find contentment. His advice is simple: keep talking with God, feed your mind on large and true thoughts of Him, and stay faithful when prayer feels dry. Today the bare tree still speaks. A season that looks dead is not the end of the story.

PRACTICE

Find one ordinary thing you pass every day: a tree, a window, a kettle. Each time you see it today, let it remind you that God is present and at work, even when nothing seems to be happening. Say a single word of thanks.

KEY LINE

That we should establish ourselves in a sense of God'S Presence, by continually conversing with Him.

MY OWN NOTES

Second Conversation

THAT HE had always been governed by love, without selfish views; and that having resolved to make the love of GOD the *end* of all his actions, he had found reasons to be well satisfied with his method. That he was pleased when he could take up a straw from the ground for the love of GOD, seeking Him only, and nothing else, not even His gifts.

That he had been long troubled in mind from a certain belief that he should be damned; that all the men in the world could not have persuaded him to the contrary; but that he had thus reasoned with himself about it: *I engaged in a religious life only for the love of* GOD, *and I have endeavored to act only for Him; whatever becomes of me, whether I be lost or saved, I will always continue to act purely for the love of* GOD. *I shall have this good at least, that till death I shall have done all that is in me to love Him*. That this trouble of mind had lasted four years; during which time he had suffered much. But that at last he had seen that this trouble arose from want of faith; and that since then he had passed his life in perfect liberty and continual joy. That he had placed his sins betwixt him and GOD, as it were, to tell Him that he did not deserve His favors, but that GOD still continued to bestow them in abundance.

That in order to form a habit of conversing with GOD continually, and referring all we do to Him, we must at first apply to Him with some diligence: but that after a little care we should find His love inwardly excite us to it without any difficulty.

That he expected after the pleasant days GOD had given him, he should have his turn of pain and suffering; but that he was not uneasy about it, knowing very well, that as he could do nothing of himself, GOD would not fail to give him the strength to bear it.

That when an occasion of practicing some virtue offered, he addressed himself to GOD, saying, LORD, *I cannot do this unless Thou enablest me*: and that then he received strength more than sufficient.

That when he had failed in his duty, he only confessed his fault, saying to GOD, *I shall never do otherwise, if You leave me to myself; it is You who must hinder my falling, and mend what is amiss*. That after this, he gave himself no further uneasiness about it.

That we ought to act with GOD in the greatest simplicity, speaking to Him frankly and plainly, and imploring His assistance in our affairs, just as they happen. That GOD never failed to grant it, as he had often experienced.

That he had been lately sent into Burgundy, to buy the provision of wine for the society, which was a very unwelcome task for him, because he had no turn for business, and because he was lame and could not go about the boat but by rolling himself over the casks. That however he gave himself no uneasiness about it, nor about the purchase of the wine. That he said to GOD, *It was His business he was about*, and that he afterwards found it very well performed. That he had been sent into Auvergne, the year before, upon the same account; that he could not tell how the matter passed, but that it proved very well.

So, likewise, in his business in the kitchen (to which he had naturally a great aversion), having accustomed himself to do everything there for the love of GOD, and with prayer, upon all occasions, for His grace to do his work well, he had found everything easy, during fifteen years that he had been employed there.

That he was very well pleased with the post he was now in; but that he was as ready to quit that as the former, since he was always pleasing himself in every condition, by doing little things for the love of GOD.

That with him the set times of prayer were not different from other times; that he retired to pray, according to the directions of his Superior, but that he did not want such retirement, nor ask for it, because his greatest business did not divert him from GOD.

That as he knew his obligation to love GOD in all things, and as he endeavored so to do, he had no need of a director to advise him, but that he needed much a Confessor to absolve him. That he was very sensible of his faults, but not discouraged by them; that he confessed them to GOD, but did not plead against Him to excuse them. When he had so done, he peaceably resumed his usual practice of love and adoration.

That in his trouble of mind, he had consulted nobody, but knowing only by the light of faith that GOD was present, he contented himself with directing all his actions to Him, *i.e.*, doing them with a desire to please Him, let what would come of it.

That useless thoughts spoil all: that the mischief began there; but that we ought to reject them, as soon as we perceived their impertinence to the matter in hand, or our salvation; and return to our communion with GOD.

That at the beginning he had often passed his time appointed for prayer, in rejecting wandering thoughts, and falling back into them. That he could never regulate his devotion by certain methods as some do. That nevertheless, at first he had *meditated* for some time, but afterwards that went off, in a manner he could give no account of.

That all bodily mortifications and other exercises are useless, except as they serve to arrive at the union with GOD by love; that he had well considered this, and found it the shortest way to go straight to Him by a continual exercise of love, and doing all things for His sake.

That we ought to make a great difference between the acts of the *understanding* and those of the *will*: that the first were comparatively of little value, and the others, all. That our only business was to love and delight ourselves in GOD.

That all possible kinds of mortification, if they were void of the love of GOD, could not efface a single sin. That we ought, without anxiety, to expect the pardon of our sins from the Blood of JESUS CHRIST, only endeavoring to love Him with all our hearts. That GOD seemed to have granted the greatest favors to the greatest sinners, as more signal monuments of his mercy.

That the greatest pains or pleasures of this world, were not to be compared with what he had experienced of both kinds in a spiritual state: so that he was careful for nothing and feared nothing, desiring only one thing of GOD, viz., that he might not offend Him.

That he had no scruples; for, said he, when I *fail* in my duty, I readily acknowledge it, saying, *I am used to do so: I shall never do otherwise, if I am left to myself*. I fail not, then I give GOD thanks, acknowledging the strength comes from Him.

✦

REFLECTION

Here we meet the heart of his method: love, not selfish gain. He is happy to pick up a straw from the floor if he does it for God. He also tells of four hard years when he was sure he was lost, and how he chose to keep loving God anyway, until peace came. When he failed, he did not sink into worry; he told God plainly that without Him he would always fail, and went on. The business trip to buy wine, rolling over the casks with his lame leg, and the kitchen he naturally disliked both became places of prayer. When he says bodily "mortifications" (the penances common in his day) are useless without love, he is not recommending them; he is pointing past them to what matters. Small acts, offered in love, are enough.

PRACTICE

Choose one small chore you dislike: unloading the dishwasher, answering a dull email, folding laundry. Before you begin, say quietly, "This is for You." When

you notice you have drifted into grumbling, simply say it again and keep going.

KEY LINE

That he was pleased when he could take up a straw from the ground for the love of God, seeking Him only, and nothing else, not even His gifts.

MY OWN NOTES

Third Conversation

He told me that the *foundation of the spiritual life* in *him*, had been a high notion and esteem of God in faith; which when he had once well conceived, he had no other care at first, but faithfully to reject every other thought, *that he might perform all his actions for the love of* God. That when sometimes he had not thought of God for a good while, he did not disquiet himself for it; but after having acknowledged his wretchedness to God, he returned to Him with so much the greater trust in Him, as he had found himself wretched through forgetting Him.

That the trust we put in God, honors Him much, and draws down great graces.

That it was impossible, not only that God should deceive, hut also that He should long let a soul suffer which is perfectly resigned to Him, and resolved to endure everything for His sake.

That he had so often experienced the ready succors of Divine Grace upon all occasions, that from the same experience, when he had business to do, he did not think of it beforehand; but when it was time to do it, he found in God, as in a clear mirror, all that was fit for him to do. That of late he had acted thus, without anticipating care; but before the experience above mentioned, he had used it in his affairs.

When outward business diverted him a little from the thought of God, a fresh remembrance coming from God invested his soul,

and so inflamed and transported him that it was difficult for him to contain himself.

That he was more united to GOD in his outward employments, than when he left them for devotion in retirement.

That he expected hereafter some great pain of body or mind; that the worst that could happen to him was, to lose that sense of GOD which he had enjoyed so long; but that the goodness of GOD assured him He would not forsake him utterly, and that He would give him strength to bear whatever evil He permitted to happen to him; and therefore that he feared nothing, and had no occasion to consult with anybody about his state. That when he had attempted to do it, he had always come away more perplexed; and that as he was conscious of his readiness to lay down his life for the love of GOD, he had no apprehension of danger. That perfect resignation to GOD was a sure way to heaven, a way in which we had always sufficient light for our conduct.

That in the beginning of the spiritual life, we ought to be faithful in doing our duty and denying ourselves; but after that, unspeakable pleasures followed; that in difficulties we need only have recourse to JESUS CHRIST, and beg his grace; with that everything became easy.

That many do not advance in the Christian progress because they stick in penances, and particular exercises, while they neglect the love of GOD, which is the *end*. That this appeared plainly by their works, and was the *reason* why we see so little solid virtue.

That there needed neither art nor science for going to GOD, but only a heart resolutely determined to apply itself to nothing but Him, or for *His* sake, and to love him only.



REFLECTION

Brother Lawrence explains where his spiritual life began: a deep, trusting sense of how great and good God is. When he noticed he had forgotten God for a

while, he did not scold himself. He admitted it and came back with even more trust. He found that he did not need to worry about tasks ahead of time; when the moment came, he saw what to do "as in a clear mirror." Surprisingly, he felt closer to God while working than when he withdrew for devotions. He warns that people can get stuck in penances and special exercises and forget the point, which is love. His closing line takes away every excuse: no special skill or learning is needed, only a willing heart.

PRACTICE

The next time you realize you have gone hours without a thought of God, skip the guilt. Say, "Here I am again," and return. Notice whether coming back gently feels different from coming back with a scolding.

KEY LINE

That there needed neither art nor science for going to God, but only a heart resolutely determined to apply itself to nothing but Him

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MY OWN NOTES

Fourth Conversation

He discoursed with me very frequently, and with great openness of heart concerning his manner of *going* to God, whereof some part is related already.

He told me that all consists *in one hearty renunciation* of everything which we are sensible does not lead to God; that we might accustom ourselves to a continual conversation with Him, with freedom and in simplicity. That we need only to recognize God intimately present with us, to address ourselves to Him every moment, that we may beg His assistance for knowing His will in things doubtful, and for rightly performing those which we plainly see he requires of us, offering them to Him before we do them, and giving Him thanks when we have done.

That in this conversation with God, we are also employed in praising, adoring and loving Him incessantly, for His infinite goodness and perfection.

That, without being discouraged on account of our sins, we should pray for His grace with a perfect confidence, as relying upon the infinite merits of our Lord Jesus Christ. That God never failed offering us His grace at each action; that he distinctly perceived it, and never failed of it, unless when his thoughts had wandered from a sense of God'S Presence, or he had forgotten to ask His assistance.

That God always gave us light in our doubts, when we had no other design but ask to please Him.

That our sanctification did not depend upon *changing* our works, but in doing that for GOD's sake, which we commonly do for our own. That it was lamentable to see how many people mistook the means for the end, addicting themselves to certain works, which they performed very imperfectly, by reason of their human or selfish regards.

That the most excellent method he had found of going to GOD, was that of doing our common business without any view of pleasing men,[1] and (as far as we are capable) purely for the love of GOD.

That it was a great delusion to think that the times of prayer ought to differ from other times: that we are as strictly obliged to adhere to GOD by action in the time of action, as by prayer in the season of prayer.

That his prayer was nothing else but a sense of the presence of GOD, his soul being at that time insensible to everything but Divine love: and that when the appointed times of prayer were past, he found no difference, because he still continued with GOD, praising and blessing Him with all his might, so that he passed his life in continual joy; yet hoped that GOD would give him somewhat to suffer, when he should grow stronger.

That we ought, once for all, heartily to put our whole trust in GOD, and make a total surrender of ourselves to Him, secure that He would not deceive us.

That we ought not to be weary of doing little things for the love of GOD, who regards not the greatness of the work, but the love with which it is performed. That we should not wonder if, in the beginning, we often failed in our endeavors, but that at last we should gain a habit, which will naturally produce its acts in us, without our care, and to our exceeding great delight.

That the whole substance of religion was faith, hope and charity; by the practice of which we become united to the will of GOD: that all besides is indifferent, and to be used as a means that we may arrive at our end, and be swallowed up therein, by faith and charity.

That all things are possible to him who *believes*—that they are less difficult to him who *hopes*—that they are more easy to him who *loves*, and still more easy to him who perseveres in the practice of these three virtues.

That the end we ought to propose to ourselves is to become, in this life, the most perfect worshippers of GOD we can possibly be, as we hope to be through all eternity.

That when we enter upon the spiritual life, we should consider, and examine to the bottom, what we are. And then we should find ourselves worthy of all contempt, and not deserving indeed the name of Christians: subject to all kinds of misery and numberless accidents, which trouble us and cause perpetual vicissitudes in our health, in our humors, in our internal and external dispositions; in fine, persons whom GOD would humble by many pains and labors, as well within as without. After this we should not wonder that troubles, temptations, oppositions and contradictions happen to us from men. We ought, on the contrary, to submit ourselves to them, and bear them as long as GOD pleases, as things highly advantageous to us.

That the greater perfection a soul aspires after, the more dependent it is upon Divine grace.

[2]Being questioned by one of his own society (to whom he was obliged to open himself) by what means he had attained such an habitual sense of GOD, he told him that, since his first coming to the monastery, he had considered GOD as the end of all his thoughts and desires, as the mark to which they should tend, and in which they should terminate.

That in the beginning of his novitiate, he spent the hours appointed for private prayer in thinking of GOD, so as to convince his mind of, and to impress deeply upon his heart, the Divine existence, rather by devout sentiments, and submission to the lights of faith, than by studied reasonings and elaborate meditations. That by this short and sure method, he exercised himself in the knowledge and love of GOD,

resolving to use his utmost endeavor to live, in a continual sense of His Presence, and if possible, never to forget Him more.

That when he had thus in prayer filled his mind with great sentiments of that infinite Being, he went to his work appointed in the kitchen (for he was cook to the society); there having first considered severally the things his office required, and when and how each thing was to be done, he spent all the intervals of his time, as well before as after his work, in prayer.

That when he began his business, he said to GOD, with a filial trust in Him, "O my GOD, since Thou art with me, and I must now, in obedience to Thy commands, apply my mind to these outward things, I beseech Thee to grant me the grace to continue in Thy Presence; and to this end do Thou prosper me with Thy assistance, receive all my works, and possess all my affections."

As he proceeded in his work, he continued his familiar conversation with his Maker,—imploring His grace, and offering to Him all his actions.

When he had finished, he examined himself how he had discharged his duty; if he found *well*, he returned thanks to GOD; if otherwise, he asked pardon; and without being discouraged, he set his mind right again, and continued his exercise of the *presence* of GOD, as if he had never deviated from it. "Thus," said he, "by rising after my falls, and by frequently renewed acts of faith and love, I am come to a state wherein it would be as difficult for me not to think of GOD as it was at first to accustom myself to it."

As brother Lawrence had found such an advantage in walking in the presence of GOD, it was natural for him to recommend it earnestly to others; but his example was a stronger inducement than any arguments he could propose. His very countenance was edifying, such a sweet and calm devotion appearing in it as could not but effect the beholders. And it was observed that in the greatest hurry of business in the kitchen, he still preserved his recollection and heavenly-mindedness. He was never

hasty nor loitering, but did each thing in its season, with an even, uninterrupted composure and tranquility of spirit. "The time of business," said he, "does not with me differ from the time of prayer; and in the noise and clatter of my kitchen, while several persons are at the same time calling for different things, I possess GOD in as great tranquility as if I were upon my knees at the blessed sacrament."

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[1] Gal. i, 10; Eph. vi, 5, 6.

[2] The particulars which follow are collected from other accounts of Brother Lawrence.

✦

REFLECTION

This longest conversation gathers his teaching together. Holiness does not mean changing our jobs, but doing what we already do for God's sake instead of our own. Prayer time and work time should not be two different worlds. We ask God's help before a task, keep company with Him during it, and thank Him afterward; if it went badly, we ask pardon and start again without discouragement. His sharp words about our own misery belong to the humble language of his age; their point is that we should not be shocked by trouble. The section ends with a picture of him in a busy kitchen, people calling for different things at once, while he stays calm. Peace is possible in the middle of the noise, not only away from it.

PRACTICE

Before a busy stretch of your day (cooking dinner, a meeting, the school run), pray his kitchen prayer in your own words: "You are with me. Help me stay with You." At the end, take ten seconds to say thanks or sorry, then let it go.

KEY LINE

in the noise and clatter of my kitchen, while several persons are at the same time calling for different things, I possess God in as great tranquility as if I were upon my knees at the blessed sacrament.

MY OWN NOTES

First Letter

SINCE YOU desire so earnestly that I should communicate to you the method by which I arrived at that *habitual sense of* GOD'S *Presence*, which our LORD, of His mercy, has been pleased to vouch-safe to me, I must tell you that it is with great difficulty that I am prevailed on by your importunities; and now I do it only upon the terms that you show my letter to nobody. If I knew that you should let it be seen, all the desire that I have for your advancement would not be able to determine me to it. The account I can give you is:

Having found in many books different methods of going to GOD, and divers practices of the spiritual life, I thought this would serve rather to puzzle me than facilitate what I sought after, which was nothing but how to become wholly GOD'S. This made me resolve to give the all for the all; so after having given myself wholly to GOD, that He might take away my sin, *I renounced, for the love of Him, everything that was not He; and I began to live as if there was none but He and I in the world*. Sometimes I considered myself before Him as a poor criminal at the feet of his judge; at other times I beheld Him in my heart as my FATHER, as my GOD: I worshipped Him the oftenest that I could, keeping my mind in His holy Presence, and recalling it as often as I found it wandered from Him. I found no small pain in this exercise, and yet I continued it, notwithstanding all the difficulties that occurred, without troubling or disquieting myself when my mind had wandered involuntarily. I made this my business as much all the day long as at the appointed times of

prayer; for at all times, every hour, every minute, even in the height of my business, I drove away from my mind everything that was capable of interrupting my thought of GOD.

Such has been my common practice ever since I entered in religion; and, though I have done it very imperfectly, yet I have found great advantages by it. These, I well know, are to be imputed to the mere mercy and goodness of GOD, because we can do nothing without Him; and *I* still less than any. But when we are faithful to keep ourselves in His holy Presence, and set Him always before us, this not only hinders our offending Him, and doing anything that may displease Him, at least wilfully, but it also begets in us a holy freedom, and, if I may so speak, a familiarity with GOD, wherewith we ask, and that successfully, the graces we stand in need of. In fine, by often repeating these acts, they become *habitual*, and the presence of GOD rendered as it were *natural to* us. Give Him thanks, if you please, with me, for His great goodness towards me, which I can never sufficiently admire, for the many favors He has done to so miserable a sinner as I am. May all things praise Him. Amen.

I am, in our LORD, yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

A friend has begged him to explain his method, and he agrees only if the letter is kept private. He confesses that the many books on prayer confused him more than they helped. So he made one decision: to give "the all for the all," his whole self in return for God Himself, and to live as if there were only God and him in the world. Sometimes he came before God as a guilty man before a judge, at other times as a child before a father. The practice was not easy at first. His mind wandered, and he kept bringing it back, without anxiety. Over time the habit became almost natural, and it gave him a holy freedom, a kind of friendship with God.

PRACTICE

Set a gentle reminder on your phone for three times today. When it goes off, stop for one breath, notice where your mind has wandered, and bring it back to God with a short word such as "Father" or "You are here."

KEY LINE

I worshipped Him the oftenest that I could, keeping my mind in His holy Presence, and recalling it as often as I found it wandered from Him.

MY OWN NOTES

Second Letter

To the Reverend—

Not finding my manner of life in books, although I have no difficulty about it, yet, for greater security, I shall be glad to know your thoughts concerning it.

In a conversation some days since with a person of piety, he told me the spiritual life was a life of grace, which begins with servile fear, which is increased by hope of eternal life, and which is consummated by pure love. That each of these states had its different stages, by which one arrives at last at that blessed consummation.

I have not followed all these methods. On the contrary, from I know not what instincts, I found they discouraged me. This was the reason why, at my entrance into religion, I took a resolution to give myself up to God, as the best return I could make for His love; and, for the love of Him, to renounce all besides.

For the first year I commonly employed myself during the time set apart for devotion with the thought of death, judgment, heaven, hell, and my sins. Thus continued some years, applying my mind carefully the rest of the day, and even in the midst of my business, *to the presence of* God, whom I considered always as *with* me, often as *in* me.

At length I came insensibly to do the same thing during my set time of prayer, which caused in me great delight and consolation. This

practice produced in me so high an esteem for GOD, that *faith* alone was capable to satisfy me in that point.[3]

Such was my beginning; and yet I must tell you that for the first ten years I suffered much: the apprehension that I was not devoted to GOD as I wished to be, my past sins always present to my mind, and the great unmerited favors which GOD did me, were the matter and source of my sufferings. During this time I fell often, and rose again presently. It seemed to me that all creatures, reason, and GOD Himself were against me; and *faith* alone for me. I was troubled sometimes with thoughts that to believe I had received such favors was an effect of my presumption, which pretended to be *at once* where others arrive with difficulty; at other times that it was a wilful delusion, and that there was no salvation for me.

When I thought of nothing but to end my days in these troubles (which did not at all diminish the trust I had in GOD, and which served only to increase my faith), I found myself changed all at once; and my soul, which, till that time, was in trouble, felt a profound inward peace, as if she were in her centre and place of rest.

Ever since that time I walk before GOD simply, in faith, with humility and with love; and I apply myself diligently to do nothing and think nothing which may displease Him. I hope that when I have done what I can, He will do with me what He pleases.

As for what passes in me at present, I cannot express it. I have no pain or difficulty about my state, because I have no will but that of GOD, which I endeavor to accomplish in all things, and to which I am so resigned that I would not take up a straw from the ground against His order, or from any other motive than purely that of love to Him.

I have quitted all forms of devotion and set prayers but those to which my state obliges me. And I make it my business only to persevere in His holy presence, wherein I keep myself by a simple attention, and a general fond regard to GOD, which I may call an *actual presence of* GOD; or, to speak better, an habitual, silent and secret conversation of the soul

with GOD, which often causes me joys and raptures inwardly, and sometimes also outwardly, so great, that I am forced to use means to moderate them and prevent their appearance to others.

In short, I am assured beyond all doubt that my soul has been with GOD above these thirty years. I pass over many things that I may not be tedious to you, yet I think it proper to inform you after what manner I consider myself before GOD, whom I behold as my King.

I consider myself as the most wretched of men, full of sores and corruption, and who has committed all sorts of crimes against his King; touched with a sensible regret, I confess to him all my wickedness, I ask His forgiveness, I abandon myself in His hands that He may do what he pleases with me. The King, full of mercy and goodness, very far from chastising me, embraces me with love, makes me eat at His table, serves me with His own hands, gives me the key of His treasures; He converses and delights Himself with me incessantly, in a thousand and a thousand ways, and treats me in all respects as His favorite. It is thus I consider myself from time to time in His holy presence.

My most useful method is this simple attention, and such a general passionate regard to GOD; to whom I find myself often attached with greater sweetness and delight than that of an infant at the mother's breast; so that, if I dare use the expression, I should choose to call this state the bosom, of GOD, for the inexpressible sweetness which I taste and experience there.

If sometimes my thoughts wander from it by necessity or infirmity, I am presently recalled by inward motions so charming and delicious that I am ashamed to mention them. I desire your reverence to reflect rather upon my great wretchedness, of which you are fully informed, than upon the great favors which GOD does me, all unworthy and ungrateful as I am.

As for my set hours of prayer, they are only a continuation of the same exercise. Sometimes I consider myself there as a stone before a carver, whereof he is to make a statue; presenting myself thus before

GOD, I desire Him to form His perfect image in my soul, and make me entirely like Himself.

At other times, when I apply myself to prayer, I feel all my spirit and all my soul lift itself up without any care or effort of mine, and it continues as it were suspended and firmly fixed in GOD, as in its centre and place of rest.

I know that some charge this state with inactivity, delusion and self-love. I confess that it is a holy inactivity, and would be a happy self-love, if the soul in that state were capable of it; because, in effect, while she is in this repose, she cannot be disturbed by such acts as she was formerly accustomed to, and which were then her support, but which would now rather hinder than assist her.

Yet I cannot bear that this should be called delusion; because the soul which thus enjoys GOD desires herein nothing but Him. If this be delusion in me, it belongs to GOD to remedy it. Let Him do what He pleases with me; I desire only Him, and to be wholly devoted to Him. You will, however, oblige me in sending me your opinion, to which I always pay a great deference, for I have a singular esteem for your reverence, and am in our LORD,

Yours, &c.

✦

[3] *I suppose he means* that all distinct notions he could form of GOD, were unsatisfactory, because he perceived them to be unworthy of GOD; and therefore his mind was not to be satisfied but by the views of *faith*, which apprehend GOD as infinite and incomprehensible, as He is in Himself, and not as He can be conceived by human ideas.

REFLECTION

Writing to a priest, Brother Lawrence asks whether his way of life is sound, since he cannot find it described in books. He is honest about ten painful years of doubt and fear before a deep peace arrived "all at once." Since then, he says,

he simply walks before God in faith, humility and love, dropping most set forms of prayer for a quiet, loving attention. He describes himself as a sinner before a King who, instead of punishing him, welcomes him to His table. He also uses a lovely image: he is like a stone before a sculptor, asking God to shape His image in him. Prayer here is less about effort and more about letting oneself be formed.

PRACTICE

Sit for two minutes before work or bed. Do not try to say anything clever. Picture yourself as an unfinished stone in a sculptor's workshop, and simply say, "Shape me today." Then go on with your evening.

KEY LINE

Sometimes I consider myself there as a stone before a carver, whereof he is to make a statue

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MY OWN NOTES

Third Letter

WE HAVE a GOD who is infinitely gracious and knows all our wants. I always thought that He would reduce you to extremity. He will come in His own time, and when you least expect it. Hope in Him more than ever; thank Him with me for the favors he does you, particularly for the fortitude and patience which He gives you in your afflictions. It is a plain mark of the care He takes of you. Comfort yourself, then, with Him, and give thanks for all.

I admire also the fortitude and bravery of Mr. ——. God has given him a good disposition and a good will; but there is in him still a little of the world, and a great deal of youth. I hope the affliction which GOD has sent him will prove a wholesome remedy to him, and make him enter into himself. It is an accident which should engage him to put all his trust in *Him* who accompanies him everywhere. Let him think of Him as often as he can, especially in the greatest dangers. A little lifting up of the heart suffices. A little remembrance of GOD, one act of inward worship, though upon a march, and a sword in hand, are prayers, which, however short, are nevertheless very acceptable to GOD; and far from lessening a soldier's courage in occasions of danger, they best serve to fortify it.

Let him then think of GOD the most he can. Let him accustom himself, by degrees, to this small but holy exercise. No one will notice it, and nothing is easier than to repeat often in the day these little internal adorations. Recommend to him, if you please, that he think of GOD the

most he can, in the manner here directed. It is very fit and most necessary for a soldier, who is daily exposed to the dangers of life. I hope that GOD will assist him and all the family, to whom I present my service, being theirs and Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

This short letter offers comfort to a friend in hardship and sends advice to a young soldier who has been through some misfortune. Brother Lawrence's counsel is wonderfully practical. You do not need long prayers or a quiet chapel. A quick lift of the heart, a brief remembrance of God, even on the march with a sword in hand, is real prayer and pleasing to God. Far from making a soldier weaker, it steadies his courage. Nobody else even has to notice. He calls these moments "little internal adorations." For anyone today with a crowded, stressful life, this may be the most usable advice in the whole book: short, frequent, hidden turns toward God.

PRACTICE

On your commute or in a line at the store, try a one-sentence prayer: "Lord, I'm here with You." Repeat it each time you stop at a red light or wait for a page to load. Keep it small and private.

KEY LINE

A little lifting up of the heart suffices.

MY OWN NOTES

Fourth Letter

I HAVE taken this opportunity to communicate to you the sentiments of one of our society, concerning the admirable effects and continual assistances which he receives from *the presence of* GOD. Let you and me both profit by them.

You must know his continual care has been, for about forty years past that he has spent in religion, to be *always with* GOD, and to do nothing, say nothing, and think nothing which may displease Him; and this without any other view than purely for the love of Him, and because he deserves infinitely more.

He is now so accustomed to that *Divine Presence*, that he receives from it continual succors upon all occasions. For about thirty years, his soul has been filled with joys so continual, and sometimes so great, that he is forced to use means to moderate them, and to hinder their appearing outwardly.

If sometimes he is a little too much absent from that *Divine Presence*, GOD presently makes Himself to be felt in his soul to recall him, which often happens when he is most engaged in his outward business. He answers with exact fidelity to these inward drawings, either by an elevation of his heart towards GOD, or by a meek and fond regard to Him, or by such words as love forms upon these occasions, as for instance, *My God, here I am all devoted to Thee*: LORD, *make me according to Thy heart*. And then it seems to him (as in effect he feels it) that this GOD of love, satisfied with such few words, reposes again, and rests in

the fund and centre of his soul. The experience of these things gives him such an assurance that GOD is always in the fund or bottom of his soul, that it renders him incapable of doubting it upon any account whatever.

Judge by this what content and satisfaction he enjoys while he continually finds in himself so great a treasure. He is no longer in an anxious search after it, but has it open before him, and may take what he pleases of it.

He complains much of our blindness, and cries often that we are to be pitied who content ourselves with so little. GOD, saith he, *has infinite treasure to bestow, and we take up with a little sensible devotion, which passes in a moment. Blind as we are, we hinder GOD, and stop the current of His graces. But when He finds a soul penetrated with a lively faith, He pours into it His graces and favors plentifully: there they flow like a torrent, which, after being forcibly stopped against its ordinary course, when it has found a passage, spreads itself with impetuosity and abundance.*

Yes, we often stop this torrent by the little value we set upon it. But let us stop it no more; let us enter into ourselves and break down the bank which hinders it. Let us make way for grace; let us redeem the lost time, for perhaps we have but little left. Death follows us close; let us be well prepared for it: for we die but once; and a miscarriage *there* is irretrievable.

I say again, let us enter into ourselves. The time presses, there is no room for delay: our souls are at stake. I believe you have taken such effectual measures that you will not be surprised. I commend you for it; it is the one thing necessary. We must, nevertheless, always work at it, because not to advance in the spiritual life is to go back. But those who have the gale of the HOLY SPIRIT go forward even in sleep. If the vessel of our soul is still tossed with winds and storms, let us awake the LORD, who reposes in it, and He will quickly calm the sea.

I have taken the liberty to impart to you these good sentiments, that you may compare them with your own. It will serve again to kindle and inflame them, if by misfortune (which GOD forbid, for it would be

indeed a great misfortune) they should be, though never so little, cooled. Let us then *both* recall our first fervors. Let us profit by the example and the sentiments of this brother, who is little known of the world, but known of GOD, and extremely caressed by Him. I will pray for you; do you pray instantly for me, who am, in our LORD.

Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Brother Lawrence describes "one of our society," but the brother he means is almost certainly himself. For about forty years he has tried to stay with God in every moment. When he drifts during busy work, God seems to call him back, and he answers with a short word like "My God, here I am." He grieves that we settle for passing good feelings when God wants to pour out grace like a flooding river. Then comes a sense of urgency: life is short, so let us not waste it. The letter ends with a calming image from the Gospel storm at sea. If your inner life feels tossed by wind and waves, wake the Lord who is already there.

PRACTICE

When you feel stress rising today (an email, a deadline, a tense conversation), pause and picture the boat in the storm. Say quietly, "Lord, wake up in me." Take one slow breath before you answer or act.

KEY LINE

If the vessel of our soul is still tossed with winds and storms, let us awake the LORD, who reposes in it, and He will quickly calm the sea.

MY OWN NOTES

Fifth Letter

I RECEIVED this day two books and a letter from Sister ——, who is preparing to make her profession, and upon that account desires the prayers of your holy society, and yours in particular. I perceive that she reckons much upon them; pray do not disappoint her. Beg of GOD that she may make her sacrifice in the view of His love alone, and with a firm resolution to be wholly devoted to Him. I will send you one of these books which treat of *the presence of* GOD; a subject which, in my opinion, contains the whole spiritual life; and it seems to me that whoever duly practices it will soon become spiritual.

I know that for the right practice of it, the heart must be empty of all other things; because GOD will possess the heart *alone*; and as He cannot possess it *alone* without emptying it of all besides, so neither can He act *there*, and do in it what He pleases, unless it be left vacant to Him.

There is not in the world a kind of life more sweet and delightful than that of a continual conversation with GOD. Those only can comprehend it who practice and experience it; yet I do not advise you to do it from that motive. It is not pleasure which we ought to seek in this exercise; but let us do it from a principle of love, and because GOD would have us.

Were I a preacher, I should, above all other things, preach the practice of *the presence of* GOD; and, were I a director, I should advise all the world to do it, so necessary do I think it, and so easy too.

Ah! knew we but the want we have of the grace and assistance of GOD, we should never lose sight of Him, no, not for a moment. Believe me; make immediately a holy and firm resolution never more wilfully to forget Him, and to spend the rest of your days in His sacred presence, deprived for the love of Him, if He thinks fit, of all consolations.

Set heartily about this work, and if you do it as you ought, be assured that you will soon find the effects of it. I will assist you with my prayers, poor as they are. I recommend myself earnestly to yours and those of your holy society being theirs, and more particularly

Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

A young woman is about to take her vows as a nun, and Brother Lawrence asks for prayers for her. He then states plainly what he believes: the practice of the presence of God holds the whole spiritual life. To practice it, the heart has to make room, setting aside whatever crowds God out. He admits that this life is sweet, but he adds a careful warning. We should not do it for the good feelings. We should do it out of love, because God wants it. If he were a preacher, he says, he would preach nothing else. His closing plea is direct: decide now, firmly and kindly, not to forget God on purpose, and begin.

PRACTICE

Write one sentence on a sticky note: "Today I will not forget You on purpose." Put it where you will see it: the fridge, your monitor, the car dashboard. Each time you read it, turn toward God for a moment.

KEY LINE

There is not in the world a kind of life more sweet and delightful than that of a continual conversation with GOD.

MY OWN NOTES

Sixth Letter

To the Same.

I HAVE received from Mrs. ——, the things which you gave her for me. I wonder that you have not given me your thoughts of the little book I sent to you, and which you must have received. Pray set heartily about the practice of it in your old age: it is better late than never.

I cannot imagine how religious persons can live satisfied without the practice of *the presence of* GOD. For my part. I keep myself retired with Him in the fund or centre of my soul as much as I can; and while I am so with Him I fear nothing, but the least turning from Him is insupportable.

This exercise does not much fatigue the body; it is, however, proper to deprive it sometimes, nay often; of many little pleasures which are innocent and lawful, for GOD will not permit that a soul which desires to be devoted entirely to Him should take other pleasures than with Him: that is more than reasonable.

I do not say that therefore we must put any violent constraint upon ourselves. No, we must serve GOD in a holy freedom; we must do our business faithfully; without trouble or disquiet, recalling our mind to GOD mildly, and with tranquility, as often as we find it wandering from Him.

It is, however, necessary to put our whole trust in GOD, laying aside all other cares, and even some particular forms of devotion, though very

good in themselves, yet such as one often engages in unreasonably, because these devotions are only means to attain to the end. So when by this exercise of *the presence of* GOD we are *with Him* who is our end, it is then useless to return to the means; but we may continue with Him our commerce of love, persevering in His holy presence, one while by an act of praise, of adoration or of desire; one while by an act of resignation or thanksgiving; and in all the ways which our spirit can invent.

Be not discouraged by the repugnance which you may find in it from nature; you must do yourself violence. At the first one often thinks it lost time, but you must go on, and resolve to persevere in it to death, notwithstanding all the difficulties that may occur. I recommend myself to the prayers of your holy society, and yours in particular. I am, in our LORD,

Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Brother Lawrence gently scolds a friend for not saying what she thought of the little book he sent, then urges her to start the practice now, in old age: "better late than never." He describes his own habit of staying "retired" with God in the "fund or centre," the deep center, of his soul. He mentions giving up small, harmless pleasures, a common discipline of his time, but at once adds that there must be no "violent constraint." The heart of the letter is freedom: do your work faithfully, and when the mind drifts, bring it back mildly. Devotions are means, not the goal. Once you are with God, you can simply stay and talk with Him in praise, thanks, longing, or quiet surrender. It is never too late to begin.

PRACTICE

Pick one ordinary moment today, such as waiting for the kettle or a page to load. Instead of reaching for your phone, turn inward and say one honest

word to God: "Thanks," "Help," or simply "Here." Then go back to what you were doing.

KEY LINE

we must serve God in a holy freedom

MY OWN NOTES

Seventh Letter

I PITY you much. It will be of great importance if you can leave the care of your affairs to ——, and spend the remainder of your life only in worshiping GOD. He requires no great matters of us; a little remembrance of Him from time to time; a little adoration; sometimes to pray for His grace, sometimes to offer Him your sufferings, and sometimes to return Him thanks for the favors He has given you, and still gives you, in the midst of your troubles, and to console yourself with Him the oftenest you can. Lift up your heart to Him, sometimes even at your meals, and when you are in company: the least little remembrance will always be acceptable to Him. You need not cry very loud; He is nearer to us than we are aware of.

It is not necessary for being with GOD to be always at church: we may make an oratory of our heart wherein to retire from time to time to converse with Him in meekness, humility and love. Every one is capable of such familiar conversation with GOD, some more, some less: He knows what we can do. Let us begin, then. Perhaps He expects but one generous resolution on our part. Have courage. We have but little time to live; you are near sixty-four, and I am almost eighty. Let us live and die with GOD. Sufferings will be sweet and pleasant to us while we are with Him; and the greatest pleasures will be, without Him, a cruel punishment to us. May He be blessed for all. Amen.

Accustom yourself, then, by degrees thus to worship Him, to beg His grace, to offer Him your heart from time to time in the midst of your

business, even every moment, if you can. Do not always scrupulously confine yourself to certain rules, or particular forms of devotion, but act with a general confidence in GOD, with love and humility. You may assure —— of my poor prayers, and that I am their servant, and particularly

Yours in our LORD, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Writing to someone weighed down by worries, Lawrence lowers the bar to something anyone can reach. God "requires no great matters of us": just a little remembrance now and then, a brief act of worship, a request for help, a word of thanks. You can do it at the dinner table or in a crowded room, and you don't need to raise your voice, because God is closer than we think. Church is not the only place to pray; he says we can make "an oratory," a small private chapel, inside our own heart. He reminds his friend that she is nearly sixty-four and he almost eighty, so time is short, but his tone is encouraging rather than grim. Begin, have courage, and don't be a slave to rules.

PRACTICE

At one meal today, before the first bite or halfway through, pause for a single breath and remember God silently. No one at the table needs to notice. Let that brief, hidden moment be the "oratory" of your heart.

KEY LINE

He is nearer to us than we are aware of.

MY OWN NOTES

Eighth Letter

(Concerning wandering thoughts in Prayer.)

YOU TELL me nothing new; you are not the only one that is troubled with wandering thoughts. Our mind is extremely roving; but, as the will is mistress of all our faculties, she must recall them, and carry them to GOD as their last end.

When the mind, for want of being sufficiently reduced by recollection at our first engaging in devotion, has contracted certain bad habits of wandering and dissipation, they are difficult to overcome, and commonly draw us, even against our wills, to the things of the earth.

I believe one remedy for this is to confess our faults, and to humble ourselves before GOD. I do not advise you to use multiplicity of words in prayer: many words and long discourses being often the occasions of wandering. Hold yourself in prayer before GOD, like a dumb or paralytic beggar at a rich man's gate. Let it be *your* business to keep your mind in the presence of the LORD. If it sometimes wander and withdraw itself from Him, do not much disquiet yourself for that: trouble and disquiet serve rather to distract the mind than to re-collect it: the will must bring it back in tranquility. If you persevere in this manner, GOD will have pity on you.

One way to re-collect the mind easily in the time of prayer, and preserve it more in tranquility, is *not to let it wander too far at other times*: you should keep it strictly in the presence of GOD; and being

accustomed to think of Him often, you will find it easy to keep your mind calm in the time of prayer, or at least to recall it from its wanderings.

I have told you already at large, in my former letters, of the advantages we may draw from this practice of the presence of GOD: let us set about it seriously, and pray for one another.

Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Here is a letter for anyone whose mind wanders in prayer, which is everyone. "You tell me nothing new," Lawrence begins, kindly. Our minds are restless, but the will can calmly lead them back. He advises against piling up words, since long speeches often give the mind more room to roam. His picture is unforgettable: stand before God like a beggar who cannot speak or move, simply waiting at a rich man's gate. Above all, don't fret when your attention slips; worrying only scatters you more. And his practical secret: the easiest way to stay focused during prayer is to let your thoughts return to God often during the rest of the day, so that prayer time is no longer a sudden leap but a familiar homecoming.

PRACTICE

Sit for three minutes in silence before God, without words. Each time a thought pulls you away, notice it without scolding yourself and come back, like a beggar who stays at the gate. Count the returns as small successes, not failures.

KEY LINE

Hold yourself in prayer before God, like a dumb or paralytic beggar at a rich man's gate.

MY OWN NOTES

Ninth Letter

THE ENCLOSED is an answer to that which I received from ——; pray deliver it to her. She seems to me full of good will, but she would go faster than grace. One does not become holy all at once. I recommend her to you: we ought to help one another by our advice, and yet more by our good examples. You will oblige me to let me hear of her from time to time, and whether she be very fervent and very obedient.

Let us thus think often that our only business in this life is to please GOD, and that all besides is but folly and vanity. You and I have lived about forty years in religion (*i.e.*, a monastic life). Have we employed them in loving and serving GOD, who by His mercy has called us to this state and for that very end? I am filled with shame and confusion when I reflect on one hand upon the great favors which GOD has done, and incessantly continues to do me; and on the other, upon the ill use I have made of them, and my small advancement in the way of perfection.

Since by His mercy He gives us still a little time, let us begin in earnest: let us repair the lost time: let us return with a full assurance to that FATHER of mercies, who is always ready to receive us affectionately. Let us renounce, let us generously renounce, for the love of Him, all that is not Himself; He deserves infinitely more. Let us think of Him perpetually. Let us put all our trust in Him. I doubt not but we shall soon find the effects of it in receiving the abundance of His grace, with which we can do all things, and without which we can do nothing but sin.

We cannot escape the dangers which abound in life without the actual and *continual* help of GOD: let us then pray to Him for it *continually*. How can we pray to Him without being with Him? How can we be with Him but in thinking of Him often? And how can we often think of Him, but by a holy habit which we should form of it? You will tell me that I am always saying the same thing. It is true, for this is the best and easiest method I know; and as I use no other, I advise all the world to do it. We must *know* before we can *love*. In order to *know* GOD, we must often *think* of Him; and when we come to *love* Him, we shall then also think of Him often, for our heart will be with our treasure. This is an argument which well deserves your consideration.

I am, Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Lawrence encloses a letter for a young woman who is eager but in a hurry; she "would go faster than grace." Holiness, he says, does not arrive all at once. He then turns to his own life, nearly forty years "in religion," meaning in a religious community, and admits honest regret at how little he has grown. Yet the regret does not sink him: there is still time, and God is a Father always ready to welcome us back. He confesses that he keeps repeating himself, because thinking often of God is the simplest method he knows. His logic is gentle and clear: we come to love what we know, we come to know by thinking of it often, and once we love, we think of it all the more.

PRACTICE

When you catch yourself impatient with your own slow progress in anything, whether prayer, a habit, or a skill, say quietly, "One does not become holy all at once," and take the next small step instead of judging the whole journey.

KEY LINE

One does not become holy all at once.

MY OWN NOTES

Tenth Letter

I HAVE had a good deal of difficulty to bring myself to write to Mr. ——, and I do it now purely because you and Madam —— desire me. Pray write the directions and send it to him. I am very well pleased with the trust which you have in GOD: I wish that He may increase it in you more and more. We cannot have too much in so good and faithful a Friend, who will never fail us in this world nor in the next.

If Mr. —— makes his advantage of the loss he has had, and puts all his confidence in GOD, He will soon give him another friend, more powerful and more inclined to serve him. He disposes of hearts as He pleases. Perhaps Mr. —— was too much attached to him he has lost. We ought to love our friends, but without encroaching upon the love due to GOD, which must be the principal.

Pray remember what I have recommended to you, which is, to think often on GOD, by day, by night, in your business, and even in your diversions. He is always near you and with you: leave Him not alone. You would think it rude to leave a friend alone who came to visit you: why then must GOD be neglected? Do not then forget Him, but think on Him often, adore Him continually, live and die with Him; this is the glorious employment of a Christian. In a word, this is our profession; if we do not know it, we must learn it. I will endeavor to help you with my prayers, and am, in our LORD, Yours, &c.

REFLECTION

Someone in Lawrence's circle has lost a friend or patron, and Lawrence answers with both comfort and honesty. God can bring new friends and support, he says, and perhaps the man leaned too heavily on the one he lost. We should love our friends deeply, but God's love must stay first. Then comes one of his most human images. If a friend came to visit and you walked off and left them sitting alone, you would think it rude. God is always near us, so why leave Him alone? Think of Him by day and by night, at work and even at play. This, he says, is a Christian's real calling, and if we don't yet know how to do it, we can learn.

PRACTICE

Treat God today as a guest in the room. When you start a new task, at your desk, in the car, or folding laundry, acknowledge Him the way you would greet a friend sitting nearby: a glance, a word, a smile.

KEY LINE

He is always near you and with you: leave Him not alone.

MY OWN NOTES

Eleventh Letter

I DO not pray that you may be delivered from your pains, but I pray GOD earnestly that He would give you strength and patience to bear them as long as He pleases. Comfort yourself with Him who holds you fastened to the cross. He will loose you when He thinks fit. Happy those who suffer with Him: accustom yourself to suffer in that manner, and seek from Him the strength to endure as much, and as long, as He shall judge to be necessary for you. The men of the world do not comprehend these truths, nor is it to be wondered at, since they suffer like what they are, and not like Christians. They consider sickness as a pain to nature, and not as a favor from GOD; and seeing it only in that light, they find nothing in it but grief and distress. But those who consider sickness as coming from the hand of GOD, as the effect of His mercy, and the means which He employs for their salvation—such, commonly find in it great sweetness and sensible consolation.

I wish you could convince yourself that GOD is often (in some sense) nearer to us, and more effectually present with us, in sickness than in health. Rely upon no other Physician; for, according to my apprehension, He reserves your cure to Himself. Put, then, all your trust in Him, and you will soon find the effects of it in your recovery, which we often retard by putting greater confidence in physic than in GOD.

Whatever remedies you make use of, they will succeed only so far as He permits. When pains come from GOD, He only can cure them. He

often sends diseases of the body to cure those of the soul. Comfort yourself with the sovereign Physician both of the soul and body.

Be satisfied with the condition in which GOD places you: however happy you may think me, I envy you. Pains and sufferings would be a paradise to me while I should suffer with my GOD; and the greatest pleasures would be hell to me if I could relish them without Him. All my consolation would be to suffer something for His sake.

I must, in a little time, go to GOD. What comforts me in this life is, that I now see Him *by faith*; and I see Him in such a manner as might make me say sometimes, *I believe no more, but I see*. I feel what faith teaches us, and in that assurance and that practice of faith, I will live and die with Him.

Continue then always with GOD: it is the only support and comfort for your affliction. I shall beseech Him to be with you. I present my service.

Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Lawrence writes to a friend who is ill and in pain. He prays not that her pain will end, but that she will have strength to bear it, and he calls sickness a "favor" from God. This was his faith and his comfort; it is not a claim that anyone deserves to suffer. He urges her to rely on God as her "Physician" rather than on "physic," meaning medicine. In his time doctors had few real cures, and treatments such as bleeding and purging often did harm. His point is trust and peace, not rejecting care. Today we should not read this as advice to refuse treatment: pray, and also see your doctor. The lasting gift here is his conviction that God may feel nearer in sickness than in health.

PRACTICE

If you or someone you love is unwell, keep your appointments and take your treatment, and pair each one with a short prayer: "Be with me in this." Let the waiting room become a quiet place of trust.

KEY LINE

God is often (in some sense) nearer to us, and more effectually present with us, in sickness than in health.

MY OWN NOTES

Twelfth Letter

If we were well accustomed to the exercise of *the presence of* God, all bodily diseases would be much alleviated thereby. God often permits that we should suffer a little to purify our souls and oblige us to continue *with* Him.

Take courage: offer Him your pains incessantly: pray to Him for strength to endure them. Above all, get a habit of entertaining yourself often with God, and forget Him the least you can. Adore Him in your infirmities, offer yourself to Him from time to time, and in the height of your sufferings, beseech Him humbly and affectionately (as a child his father) to make you conformable to His holy-will. I shall endeavor to assist you with my poor prayers.

God has many ways of drawing us to Himself. He sometimes hides Himself from us, but *faith* alone, which will not fail us in time of need, ought to be our support, and the foundation of our confidence, which must be all in God.

I know not how God will dispose of me. I am always happy. All the world suffer; and I, who deserve the severest discipline, feel joys so continual and so great that I can scarce contain them.

I would willingly ask of God a part of your sufferings, but that I know my weakness, which is so great, that if He left me one moment to myself I should be the most wretched man alive. And yet I know not how He can leave me alone, because faith gives me as strong a conviction as sense can do, that He never forsakes us until we have first forsaken

Him. Let us fear to leave Him. Let us be always with Him. Let us live and die in His presence. Do you pray for me, as I for you.

I am, Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

Lawrence continues writing to his sick friend. Living in God's presence, he believes, softens the burden of illness. He encourages her to offer her pains to God, to ask for strength, and to speak to Him in her weakness "as a child his father." He admits that God sometimes seems hidden, and that faith must carry us when feelings fail. He speaks of his own steady joy and says he would gladly take on some of her suffering, but knows he is too weak. These words come from an old man's faith, not from a rule that pain is good or should be sought. What remains for us is the closing promise: God does not leave us, so we can stay with Him, in sickness and in health, while also getting the care we need.

PRACTICE

On a hard day, physically or otherwise, speak to God for one minute the way a tired child speaks to a parent: plainly, without performance. Tell Him where it hurts, and ask for strength for this one day.

KEY LINE

Let us live and die in His presence.

MY OWN NOTES

Thirteenth Letter

To the Same.

I AM in pain to see you suffer so long. What gives me some ease and sweetens the feelings I have for your griefs is, that they are proofs of GOD'S love towards you. See them in that view and you will bear them more easily. As your case is, it is my opinion that you should leave off human remedies, and resign yourself entirely to the providence of GOD: perhaps He stays only for that resignation and a perfect trust in Him to cure you. Since, notwithstanding all your cares, physic has hitherto proved unsuccessful, and your malady still increases, it will not be tempting GOD to abandon yourself in His hands, and expect all from Him.

I told you in my last that He sometimes permits bodily diseases to cure the distempers of the soul. Have courage then: make a virtue of necessity. Ask of GOD, not deliverance from your pains, but strength to bear resolutely, for the love of Him, all that He should please, and as long as He shall please.

Such prayers, indeed, are a little hard to nature, but most acceptable to GOD, and sweet to those that love Him. Love sweetens pains; and when one loves GOD, one suffers for His sake with joy and courage. Do you so, I beseech you: comfort yourself with Him, who is the only Physician of all our maladies. He is the FATHER of the afflicted, always ready to help us. He loves us infinitely more than we imagine. Love

Him, then, and seek no consolation elsewhere. I hope you will soon receive it. Adieu. I will help you with my prayers, poor as they are, and shall always be, in our LORD Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

This is the hardest letter in the book for modern readers. Lawrence's friend has been ill a long time and her medicine has not helped, so he suggests she "leave off human remedies" and trust God alone. We should read this in its setting. Seventeenth-century medicine was often useless or harmful, and he saw a friend worn out by failed treatments. His real concern is surrender and peace. Please do not take this as advice to stop medical care; today, faithful trust means praying and also following good medical advice. No one is promised a cure. What we can hold onto is his tender reminder that God is the "FATHER of the afflicted" and loves us far more than we imagine.

PRACTICE

If you are facing a long illness or watching someone you love endure one, write one sentence of trust and keep it by your medicines or in your phone. Read it each time you take a dose or check in with your care team.

KEY LINE

He loves us infinitely more than we imagine.

MY OWN NOTES

Fourteenth Letter

To the Same.

I RENDER thanks to our LORD for having relieved you a little, according to your desire. I have been often near expiring, but I never was so much satisfied as then. Accordingly, I did not pray for any relief, but I prayed for strength to suffer with courage, humility and love. Ah, how sweet it is to suffer with GOD! However great the sufferings may be, receive them with love. It is paradise to suffer and be with Him; so that if in this life we would enjoy the peace of paradise we must accustom ourselves to a familiar, humble, affectionate conversation with Him. We must hinder our spirits wandering from Him upon any occasion. We must make our heart a spiritual temple, wherein to adore Him incessantly. We must watch continually over ourselves, that we may not do, nor say, nor think anything that may displease Him. When our minds are thus employed about GOD, suffering will become full of unction and consolation.

I know that to arrive at this state the beginning is very difficult, for we must act purely in faith. But though it is difficult, we know also that we can do all things with the grace of GOD, which He never refuses to them who ask it earnestly. Knock, persevere in knocking, and I answer for it that He will open to you in His due time, and grant you all at once what He has deferred during many years. Adieu! Pray to Him for me, as I pray to Him for you. I hope to see Him quickly.

I am, Yours, &c.

✦

REFLECTION

His friend is a little better, and Lawrence gives thanks. He says that when he himself was near death, he asked only for courage, humility, and love. We can honor that as his own path without making it a rule; it is fine, and fully faithful, to ask God for relief and healing. The rest of the letter turns to the inner life: speaking with God in a "familiar, humble, affectionate" way and making the heart "a spiritual temple" where we worship Him continually. He admits the beginning is hard, because it rests on faith rather than feeling. His encouragement is to keep knocking, keep asking, and trust that God answers in His own time and way.

PRACTICE

Choose a phrase to carry in your heart today, such as "You are here." Whenever you wash your hands, repeat it once, turning that small moment into a visit to the temple within.

KEY LINE

We must make our heart a spiritual temple, wherein to adore Him incessantly.

MY OWN NOTES

Fifteenth Letter

To the Same.

GOD KNOWETH best what is needful for us, and all that He does is for our good. If we knew how much He loves us, we should always be ready to receive equally and with indifference from His Hand the sweet and the bitter: all would please that came from Him. The sorest afflictions never appear intolerable, except when we see them in the wrong light. When we see them as dispensed by the hand of GOD, when we know that it is our loving FATHER who abases and distresses us, our sufferings will lose their bitterness, and become even matter of consolation.

Let all our employment be to *know* GOD: the more one *knows* Him, the more one *desires* to know Him. And as *knowledge* is commonly the measure of *love*, the deeper and more extensive our *knowledge* shall be, the greater will be our *love*: and if our love of GOD were great, we should love Him equally in pains and pleasures.

Let us not content ourselves with loving GOD for the mere sensible favors, how elevated soever, which he has done, or may do us. Such favors, though never so great, cannot bring us so near to Him as faith does in one simple act. Let us seek Him often by faith. He is within us: seek Him not elsewhere. If we do love Him alone, are we not rude, and do we not deserve blame, if we busy ourselves about trifles which do not

please and perhaps offend Him. It is to be feared these *trifles* will one day cost us dear.

Let us begin to be devoted to Him in good earnest. Let us cast everything besides out of our hearts. He would possess them alone. Beg this favor of Him. If we do what we can on our parts, we shall soon see that change wrought in us which we aspire after. I cannot thank Him sufficiently for the relaxation He has vouchsafed you. I hope from His mercy the favor to see Him within a few days.[4] Let us pray for one another.

I am, in our LORD, *Yours, &c.*

✦

[4] He took to his bed two days after, and died within the week.

✦

REFLECTION

This is Lawrence's last letter; the translator's footnote tells us he took to his bed two days later and died within the week. Writing from the edge of his life, he says God knows what we need, and that hardship looks different when we see it as held in a loving Father's hand. He returns to his old theme: the more we know God, the more we love Him. He warns against loving God only for comforting feelings, since simple faith brings us closer than any such favor. And he gives us a final, plain directive: God is within us, so we need not search elsewhere. Let go of trifles, and begin in earnest. It is a fitting farewell from a man who had practiced what he wrote.

PRACTICE

Before bed, sit quietly for two minutes. Name one "trifle" that pulled at your heart today, set it down before God, and rest in the thought that He is already within you, nearer than any worry.

KEY LINE

He is within us: seek Him not elsewhere.

MY OWN NOTES

The 30-Day Practice

Brother Lawrence said that a habit of remembering God is formed little by little: at first it takes some care, and later it becomes natural. This month-long practice is built on that promise. It asks for only a few minutes a day, and most of what it asks happens not in a quiet room but in the middle of your ordinary life.

Each day has three parts: a short passage from the book, the place where you can find it, and one small task. Read the passage in the morning, if you can, and read it twice. Then carry the task into your day. In the evening, take a minute to notice how it went. You may want to jot a line in the margin or in a notebook.

The month moves in four steps. The first week is about beginning: turning toward God and learning to pray in a few quiet words. The second week brings the practice into work, chores and the kitchen. The third week deals with the wandering mind and with faults, and how to meet both with peace rather than worry. The fourth week turns to trust in hard times and to love rather than fear. The last two days help you look back and decide how to go on.

If you miss a day, do not start over and do not scold yourself. Simply pick up where you are. That, as you will see, is the whole practice in miniature.

DAY

1

A Tree in Winter

seeing a tree stripped of its leaves, and considering that within a little time the leaves would be renewed and after that the flowers and fruit appear

FIRST CONVERSATION

Today, find one bare or ordinary thing to look at for a full minute: a tree, a houseplant, the sky from a window. Let it remind you that God is at work even where nothing seems to be happening. Say a simple thank-you before you move on.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

2

Talking with God

That we should establish ourselves in a sense of God'S Presence, by continually conversing with Him.

FIRST CONVERSATION

Think of prayer today as conversation rather than performance. Three times during the day, tell God in a sentence what you are doing and how you feel about it. Keep it as plain as a text message to a friend.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

3

Plain Speech

That we ought to act with God in the greatest simplicity, speaking to Him frankly and plainly, and imploring His assistance in our affairs, just as they happen.

SECOND CONVERSATION

Pick one task you are dreading today. Before you start it, ask God for help in your own everyday words, without any religious phrasing. Notice whether the task feels any different afterward.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

4

Little Adorations

nothing is easier than to repeat often in the day these little internal adorations

THIRD LETTER

Choose a short phrase of love or praise, no more than five words. Repeat it silently whenever you pass through a doorway today. No one needs to know.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

5

No Great Matters

He requires no great matters of us; a little remembrance of Him from time to time; a little adoration

SEVENTH LETTER

Let go of any idea that you must do something impressive for God today. Aim instead for small remembrances: a glance upward while the kettle boils, a quiet word at a red light. Count how many you manage, without judging the number.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

6

Not Alone

He is always near you and with you: leave Him not alone.

TENTH LETTER

Imagine that a dear friend has come along with you for the whole day. Every so often, turn to that friend in your heart and share what you see. Before sleep, thank God for the company.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

7

Starting Again

let us return with a full assurance to that FATHER of mercies, who is always ready to receive us affectionately

NINTH LETTER

Look back over this first week. Wherever you forgot, simply turn back now, without guilt, trusting that you are welcome. Write down one thing you want to carry into next week.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

8

A Straw from the Ground

That he was pleased when he could take up a straw from the ground for the love of God, seeking Him only, and nothing else, not even His gifts.

SECOND CONVERSATION

Today, do one tiny unseen task on purpose: pick up something from the floor, wipe a counter, refill the paper tray. Offer it to God in a word. Let it be enough that he sees it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

9

The Kitchen

having accustomed himself to do everything there for the love of God, and with prayer, upon all occasions, for His grace to do his work well, he had found everything easy

SECOND CONVERSATION

When you prepare food today, even if it is only toast or coffee, ask for grace to do it well. Pay attention to the smells and textures as you work. Treat the counter as a place of prayer.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

10

Same Work, New Reason

That our sanctification did not depend upon changing our works, but in doing that for God's sake, which we commonly do for our own.

FOURTH CONVERSATION

Choose one routine part of your job or your household. Do it exactly as usual, but tell God beforehand that you are doing it for him. At the end of the day, ask yourself whether the change of reason changed anything else.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

11

United in Busy Hours

That he was more united to God in his outward employments, than when he left them for devotion in retirement.

THIRD CONVERSATION

Pick the busiest hour of your day. Before it begins, decide on one signal, such as each new email or each time you stand up, that will remind you God is with you in the rush. Stay with it for that hour.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

12

A Prayer Before Work

I beseech Thee to grant me the grace to continue in Thy Presence; and to this end do Thou prosper me with Thy assistance, receive all my works, and possess all my affections.

FOURTH CONVERSATION

Write a one-sentence version of this prayer in your own words. Say it as you start work or your first chore today. Keep the note where you will see it tomorrow.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

13

Noise and Clatter

in the noise and clatter of my kitchen, while several persons are at the same time calling for different things, I possess God in as great tranquility as if I were upon my knees at the blessed sacrament

FOURTH CONVERSATION

When your surroundings get loud today, with children, coworkers, traffic or a crowded store, take one slow breath. Remind yourself that God is no farther away in the noise than in silence. Then carry on.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

14

At Meals and in Company

Lift up your heart to Him, sometimes even at your meals, and when you are in company: the least little remembrance will always be acceptable to Him.

SEVENTH LETTER

At one meal today, with others or alone, silently turn your heart to God partway through, not only at the start. Do the same once in a conversation. Notice how small the gesture can be.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

15

You Are Not Alone in This

you are not the only one that is troubled with wandering thoughts

EIGHTH LETTER

Today, simply notice how often your mind wanders, without trying to fix it. It may help to know that everyone has the same trouble. Be friendly toward your own restless mind.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

16

Bringing the Mind Back

If it sometimes wander and withdraw itself from Him, do not much disquiet yourself for that: trouble and disquiet serve rather to distract the mind than to re-collect it: the will must bring it back in tranquility.

EIGHTH LETTER

Sit quietly for three minutes. Each time your thoughts drift, return gently to a single word, such as "God" or "here." Do not count the times you drift; count only that you came back.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

17

A Beggar at the Gate

Hold yourself in prayer before God, like a dumb or paralytic beggar at a rich man's gate.

EIGHTH LETTER

"Dumb" here means unable to speak. Spend a few minutes in prayer today without words at all, just waiting before God like someone who has nothing to offer but need. Let that be enough.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

18

Mildly

recalling our mind to God mildly, and with tranquility, as often as we find it wandering from Him

SIXTH LETTER

Watch the tone of your inner voice today when you catch yourself distracted. If it sounds harsh, soften it on purpose, as you would speak to a child learning to walk. Then return to God.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

19

Faults Without Discouragement

That he was very sensible of his faults, but not discouraged by them

SECOND CONVERSATION

When you make a mistake today, name it honestly to God in one sentence. Ask for help, and then let it go. Notice how much energy you save by not replaying it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

20

After Forgetting

That when sometimes he had not thought of God for a good while, he did not disquiet himself for it

THIRD CONVERSATION

You will probably forget God for long stretches today. When you notice, do not go back over the lost hours. Simply turn to him now, and let the fact that you needed him draw you closer.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

21

Inward Peace

felt a profound inward peace, as if she were in her centre and place of rest

SECOND LETTER

"She" here is the soul. Lawrence found this peace only after long years of struggle, so do not demand it of yourself. Today, spend five quiet minutes simply resting in God, asking for nothing, and receive whatever peace is given.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

22

Trust

That the trust we put in God, honors Him much, and draws down great graces.

THIRD CONVERSATION

Name one worry that keeps coming back. Each time it returns today, hand it over to God in a sentence. You may still need to act on it, but you do not have to carry it alone.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

23

Strength When It Is Needed

God would not fail to give him the strength to bear it

SECOND CONVERSATION

Think of something hard that may be ahead of you. Instead of rehearsing it, ask God for strength for today only. Lawrence did not borrow tomorrow's trouble; try to follow him in that.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

24

A Faithful Friend

We cannot have too much in so good and faithful a Friend, who will never fail us in this world nor in the next.

TENTH LETTER

Recall one time when you were helped through a hard season. Thank God for it in some concrete way: a written note, a call to a person who helped, a moment of silence. Let that memory strengthen your trust now.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

25

The Storm

If the vessel of our soul is still tossed with winds and storms, let us awake the LORD, who reposes in it, and He will quickly calm the sea.

FOURTH LETTER

The image recalls the Gospel story of Jesus asleep in the boat during a storm. When you feel tossed about today, picture that boat and call on him plainly. Then take one practical step toward calm, such as a walk, a glass of water or a talk with a friend.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

26

Offering Our Troubles

sometimes to offer Him your sufferings, and sometimes to return Him thanks for the favors He has given you, and still gives you, in the midst of your troubles

SEVENTH LETTER

If something hurts today, in body or heart, offer it to God in a simple word, and then look for one gift in the same day to thank him for. You do not have to call pain good. You only have to keep God company in it. If you are ill, please take care of yourself and seek the help you need.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

27

When God Seems Hidden

He sometimes hides Himself from us,
but faith alone, which will not fail us
in time of need, ought to be our support

TWELFTH LETTER

If prayer feels empty or God seems far away, do not take that as a sign you have failed. Keep your small practice anyway, as an act of quiet faith. Tell God honestly how it feels.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

28

Loved More Than We Imagine

He loves us infinitely more than we imagine.

THIRTEENTH LETTER

Say this sentence slowly three times today. Whenever you feel fear or shame, return to it. Let love, not fear, be the reason you turn to God.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

29

Looking Back

That we should not wonder if, in the beginning, we often failed in our endeavors, but that at last we should gain a habit

FOURTH CONVERSATION

Read back over your notes from this month. Mark the day or practice that helped you most, and the one that was hardest. Be glad of any small change, and do not worry about the failures.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

DAY

30

Within

He is within us: seek Him not elsewhere.

FIFTEENTH LETTER

Choose one or two practices from this month to keep. Write them down where you will see them, and tell God simply that you mean to go on. Then begin again tomorrow, as Brother Lawrence did, every day.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ paused with God ☐ one task offered

Quick Finder

When you come to this book with a particular need, start with the sections and days listed here.

When you want to begin but don't know how — First Letter, Seventh Letter · Day 2, Day 5

When you feel your faith has gone cold — First Conversation, Fourth Letter · Day 1, Day 7

When prayer feels complicated or forced — Second Conversation, Seventh Letter · Day 3, Day 4

When you have no time to pray — Third Letter, Seventh Letter · Day 4, Day 14

When work feels meaningless — Second Conversation, Fourth Conversation · Day 9, Day 10

When you dislike the job you have to do — Second Conversation · Day 9, Day 11

When the day is noisy and crowded — Fourth Conversation, Third Conversation · Day 11, Day 13

When you are starting a busy workday — Fourth Conversation · Day 12

When you feel your efforts are too small to matter — Second Conversation, Fourth Conversation, Seventh Letter · Day 5, Day 8

When your mind won't stop wandering — Eighth Letter, Sixth Letter · Day 15, Day 16, Day 18

When you have no words to pray — Eighth Letter, Second Letter · Day 17

When you have made a mistake — Second Conversation, Fourth Conversation · Day 19

When you have forgotten God for hours or days — Third Conversation, First Letter · Day 20

When you are anxious about your own sins — Second Conversation, Fourth Conversation · Day 19, Day 28

When you fear God more than you love him — Second Conversation, Second Letter · Day 21, Day 28

When you long for inner peace — Second Letter, Sixth Letter · Day 21

When you are worried about what lies ahead — Second Conversation, Third Conversation · Day 22, Day 23

When life feels like a storm — Fourth Letter · Day 25

When you are ill or in pain — Eleventh Letter, Twelfth Letter, Fourteenth Letter · Day 26 (and please keep seeing your doctor)

When God seems far away or silent — Twelfth Letter, Fifteenth Letter · Day 27

When you are grieving a loss — Tenth Letter, Fifteenth Letter · Day 24

When someone you love is in danger — Third Letter, Tenth Letter · Day 22, Day 24

When you feel too old or too late to begin — Sixth Letter, Seventh Letter, Ninth Letter · Day 7

When you are impatient with your progress — Ninth Letter, Fourth Conversation · Day 29

When you want to keep going after this book — Ninth Letter, Fifteenth Letter · Day 29, Day 30

A Glossary

adoration — Worship of God for who he is, not for what we hope to receive. Lawrence's "little internal adorations" are brief, silent acts of love and praise made in the middle of the day.

the all for the all — Giving everything to God in return for God himself. Lawrence uses the phrase in the First Letter for his decision to hold nothing back.

blessed sacrament — The consecrated bread of Holy Communion, kept in Catholic churches and honored in prayer. Lawrence compares his busy kitchen to kneeling before it.

&c. — An old abbreviation of "et cetera," meaning *and so on*. In the letter closings, "Yours, &c." stands for the polite formulas of the time, such as *your humble servant*.

Carmelite — A member of the Order of Our Lady of Mount Carmel, a Catholic religious order devoted to prayer. Its name comes from Mount Carmel in the Holy Land.

commerce — Here, not trade but close exchange or companionship. A "commerce of love" with God means an ongoing friendship.

Confessor — A priest who hears a person's confession of sins and pronounces God's forgiveness.

conversation — In this book, a recorded talk. The four Conversations are Beaufort's notes of what Lawrence told him. Lawrence also uses the word for prayer as ongoing, friendly talk with God.

director — A spiritual director: an experienced guide who helps a person grow in prayer and the Christian life.

Discalced — Literally "unshod," barefoot or sandaled. The Discalced Carmelites were a reformed branch of the order, known for simplicity and strict prayer.

divers — Various, several, of different kinds. (Not to be confused with "diverse," though the meaning is close.)

fund — From the French *fond*: the bottom or depth. "The fund or centre of my soul" (Sixth Letter) means its innermost depth.

lay brother — A member of a religious community who takes vows but is not a priest. Lay brothers usually did the manual work of the house: cooking, cleaning, repairs, errands.

mortification — Practices of self-denial, such as fasting or bodily penances, once common in religious life as a way of training the will. Lawrence himself says they are useless unless they lead to love of God. They are explained here historically, not recommended.

novice, novitiate — A novice is a newcomer in a religious order, in a time of training and testing before taking vows. The novitiate is that period of training.

oratory — A small chapel or place of prayer. To "make an oratory of our heart" is to carry a quiet place of prayer inside you.

physic — Medicine or medical treatment. In the seventeenth century it often meant bleeding, purging and other remedies that did little good. See the note in the Afterword.

presence of God — The belief that God is always with us and within us. To "practice" it is to keep turning one's attention toward him through the day.

prior, priory — A prior is the head of a religious house; the house itself is a priory. In the text Lawrence speaks of his "Superior," the person in charge.

profession — The formal taking of religious vows at the end of the novitiate. In the Fifth Letter a sister is "preparing to make her profession."

quicken — To bring to life or enliven. The text itself explains it in the First Conversation.

recollection — Gathering one's scattered thoughts and attention back to God. To "re-collect" the mind is to gather it home.

religion — Often in this book, life in a religious order. To have "entered in religion" means to become a monk, friar or nun.

resignation — Not giving up in despair, but willingly placing oneself in God's hands and accepting his will.

scruples — Constant, anxious worry that one has sinned when one has not, or has not confessed well enough. Lawrence says he had none.

sensible — Two old meanings: felt by the senses or emotions ("sensible devotion"), and aware of something ("very sensible of his faults").

sensible consolations — Warm feelings of joy or sweetness in prayer. Lawrence values them but teaches that faith matters more than feelings.

servile fear — Fear like that of a servant afraid of punishment, as opposed to the love of a child or friend.

society — Here, the religious community Lawrence belonged to, not society at large.

succors — Help, aid, support in time of need.

Superior — The person in authority over a religious community or one of its members.

unction — Literally anointing with oil; figuratively, a sense of spiritual grace, warmth and comfort.

viz. — An old abbreviation meaning *namely* or *that is to say*.

vouchsafe — To grant or give graciously, as a favor. "Vouch-safe" in the First Letter is the same word.

Afterword: The Kitchen Was His Chapel

It is worth remembering where these pages came from. Not from a scholar's study or a bishop's palace, but from a cook with a bad leg who did not like cooking. For fifteen years he stood among pots and pans, with people calling for different things at once, and he discovered that God was as near to him there as in church. That is the quiet revolution of this book. Holiness does not wait for a better job, a calmer house or a free afternoon. It begins at the sink.

Brother Lawrence would not want to be admired. He would want to be imitated, and only in the simplest way: remember God, often, briefly, and with love. When you forget, come back. When you fail, say so and go on. That is all.

A few parts of the book need a gentle word for modern readers. In the later letters, Lawrence writes to a friend who was seriously ill and urges this friend to trust God rather than "physic," even to "leave off human remedies." We should read this in its time. Seventeenth-century medicine was often useless and sometimes harmful, and his real concern was that the sick person find peace and trust instead of fear. It is not advice for us to refuse medical care. Today, the faithful way to follow him is to pray and to see the doctor, and to trust God in both. Nor does the book promise that faith will cure every illness. It promises only that God stays with us.

In the same way, Lawrence calls his pains "favors" from God. That was his own faith, and it brought him deep comfort. It does not mean

anyone's suffering is deserved, or that we should look for it. If you are in pain, you are not being punished. You are invited, as he was, to let God keep you company.

The kitchen was his chapel. Yours may be an office, a car, a hospital room or a crowded home. It is enough.

Further Reading

These classics are in the public domain and pair well with Brother Lawrence.

Thomas à Kempis, *The Imitation of Christ* (15th century). A short, searching book of counsel on humility and the inner life, read by Catholics and Protestants for five centuries.

Augustine of Hippo, *Confessions*, translated by E. B. Pusey (1838). Augustine's story of his restless heart and its rest in God, written as a long prayer.

Francis de Sales, *Introduction to the Devout Life* (1609). A warm, practical guide to living a devout life in the middle of ordinary work and family, written for lay people.

Teresa of Ávila, *The Interior Castle* (1577). Teresa led the reform that produced the Discalced Carmelites, Brother Lawrence's own order. Here she describes the soul as a castle with God at its center.

John of the Cross, *The Dark Night of the Soul* (16th century). Teresa's fellow reformer writes on dryness in prayer and the faith that holds on when feelings fail.

Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love* (14th century). An English anchoress's tender visions of God's love, including her famous assurance that all shall be well.

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, translated by George Long (1862). A Roman emperor's private notes on calm, duty and attention to the present moment. Available in this same annotated series.

Laozi, *Tao Te Ching*, translated by James Legge (1891). The ancient Chinese classic of simplicity and quiet. Not a Christian book, but a companion for readers drawn to stillness. Available in this same annotated series.